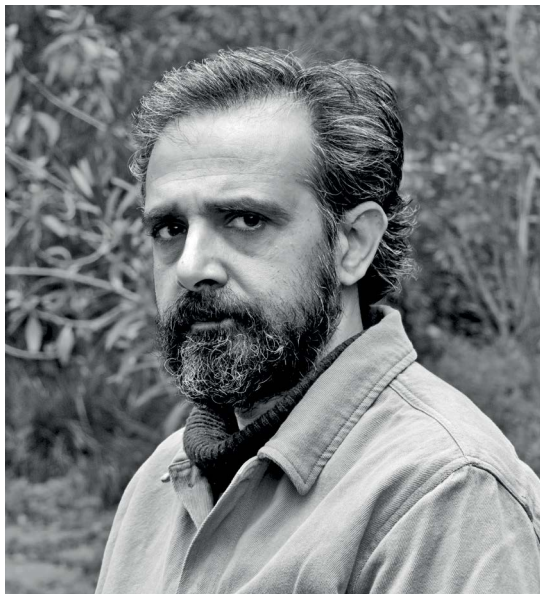
AMIT DUTTA





CLEAR NOTES Amit Dutta and a still from the animated biopic, ***Rhythm of a Flower***

CINEMA

THE TEXTURE OF **THOUGHT**

Amit Dutta's animated documentary on the life of classical singer **Kumar Gandharva** eschews a conventional narrative structure

Experimental filmmaker Amit Dutta is a workhorse. His new film, *Rhythm of a Flower*, an 81-minute animated biopic of singing legend Kumar Gandharva, was part of the International Film Festival Rotterdam in February, after winning the Golden Gateway Award at the Mumbai Film Festival last year. In March, *Stream-Story*, Dutta's documentary on the streams of the Kangra Valley in Himachal Pradesh, and how they sustain the life and culture of the locals, premiered at the Cinéma du Réel in Paris. The same month, a book of Dutta's Dogri-language poems, translated into English, was published. A book of letters on filmmaking for children in Hindi and an English-language children's book are on the way.

Categorisations of Dutta as the country's best filmmaker Indians are not aware of, with their myth-making of a reclusive genius, belie his rigorous work ethic. "I love working—it's what keeps me going," says the 47-year-old filmmaker. "I don't think I've taken a single break in years. I work quickly, but some projects, like books, require slow, sustained effort. For example, these books were conceived at different times over 5-6 years ago, yet, by coincidence, they are all arriving in the same year."

Dutta's films, revered internationally, but unreleased in India, eschew narrative or plot. Instead, they rely on "rhythm, structure, and the texture of thought—things that are often associated with literature". *Rhythm of a Flower* unfolds with seemingly disconnected and dreamlike imagery depicting Gandharva's life in an impressionistic manner, while Dutta's narration runs in the background like a prose poem.

Besides **RHYTHM OF A FLOWER,** Amit Dutta has another documentary, Stream-Story, that premiered at the Cinéma du Réel

Not that Dutta does not want to make a film with narrative. "To give you the most honest answer, I've never been able to find a producer or secure funding for a narrative film in the way I would like to make one," he says.

But alongside this desire, Dutta is fascinated with film as a language in itself, and doesn't see it as just a tool to turn words into images. "I want to probe the mystery of cinema, to understand how images and sounds create meaning beyond just storytelling," he says. "This second impulse often disrupts conventional narrative, leading me to reconfigure it in search of something more elusive."

Dutta's films are famously inaccessible in India, unless they are made available online for a short while (as MUBI did five years ago) or eager cinephiles decide to get resourceful. "I've always believed that the kind of films I make, and the subjects I choose, will naturally find their audience," he says. "Especially with the arrival of the internet, I've felt that anyone who is truly interested in such films will somehow find a way to see them." ■

–Devarsi Ghosh